danger is in throwing the baby out with the bathwater—in recasting the relationship is the political class attempting to subvert judicial independence? The memories of the dictatorial Indira years in the 1970s haven't entirely dimmed.

In a sense, Modi is perhaps closest to Indira Gandhi in his personality-driven leadership style, an imperious attitude that ensures that institutions remain subservient to the individual (even Teachers' Day has been sought to be harnessed to the cult of Modi). His run-in with Congress-appointed governors is a good example. Precedent does suggest that political appointees are expected to resign when a new government emerges. But the manner in which Modi has gone about it suggests a certain contempt for the governor's office. At least two governors—including former Gujarat governor Kamla Beniwal with whom Modi was engaged in a running battle in Gandhinagar—were packed off to Mizoram, leaving the chief minister of that state to complain that Aizawl had become a 'dumping ground' for inconvenient constitutional authorities.

Much like Indira, Modi in power is in no mood to reach out to the Opposition. The Congress has been determinedly pushing for the Leader of the Opposition post; the government has steadfastly refused. The BJP claims it's going strictly by rules framed by the Speaker's office and parliamentary convention which say a party must have at least 10 per cent of the total strength of the Lok Sabha to qualify for the status of Leader of Opposition. The Congress needs fifty-five MPs, it has just forty-four. 'When we had very few numbers in Parliament, did the Congress ever give us the Leader of the Opposition post?' a BJP minister asked me.

But this battle goes well beyond just the numbers. Right through his election campaign, Modi had spoken of a 'Congress Mukt Bharat'. It wasn't just about defeating the Congress but decimating them to the point where the party would cease to exist. By denying them the primary Opposition space, Modi has sent out a firm message that the Congress's claims to be a truly 'national' party are now under serious scrutiny.

Indeed, while a triumphant Modi seeks to stamp his authority on government with a streak of ruthlessness, the Congress leadership needs to